



(FROM EXTREME LEFT)
THAROOR AND PUSHKAR;
WITH MODI; WITH
WIFE CHRISTA GILES

this year that Sunanda first stepped into Page Three glare. Soon after, whether it was cheering Tharoor at a cricket match (what else!) or accompanying him to art exhibitions and book launches, she soon became a familiar Plus One for the minister whose divorce from his current wife Christa Giles is still to come through. Their body language didn't need a tweet from Tharoor to announce their "close relationship". Remarkd an MEA official, "He introduced her as a friend but it was obvious they have a special relationship." However inquiries with his current wife Giles who works with the UN in New York reveal that no divorce plea has been filed there. Giles was in Delhi some months ago and Tharoor took her for a holiday to Udaipur. An email from INDIA TODAY elicited no response from Giles but Tharoor's aides defend him saying, "he wanted to make the marriage work this time, but she was not prepared to stay in India".

The franchise for Kochi was Tharoor's brainchild. Tharoor, who captains the Foreign Office's cricket team, is a cricket buff and has co-authored a book on cricket. He realised that the IPL was a sure shot recipe for commercial success. He played a pivotal role in bringing the key

members of the franchise together, holding meetings at his official residence. For almost a month in the run-up to the bidding process, mission IPL had become a priority for the minister. He personally interceded several times with Modi for the Kochi team. It was a give-and-take relationship. Modi, who is a suave PR man, himself saw in Tharoor a willing minister who could get the government bottlenecks cleared and visa requests fast tracked.

"He was a friend of the minister and we were told to clear all his requests for expediting visas and passports for his IPL associates," a South Block source told INDIA TODAY.

Tharoor claims that the Kochi's franchise's unexpected success upset the plans of a lot of powerful people, who had wanted the franchise to go elsewhere. "Various attempts were made by Mr Modi and others to pressurise the consortium members to abandon their bid in favour of another city in a different state," says Tharoor in a press release. His aides explain that he is referring to the NCP boss, Sharad Pawar, who is rumoured to have a vested interest in one of the teams that lost the bid to Kochi. An angry Praful Patel retorts by saying, "What has the NCP got to do with this? This is a commercial transaction. How do we gain or lose if the shareholding pattern of the Kochi team is exposed?"

Yet, Sonia's apathy to Patel's boss is well known. Tharoor is hoping to turn this in his favour. A leading light of the St. Stephen's Shakespeare Club, Tharoor has also complained of a threat from the underworld to bolster sympathy for his cause. Yet, Tharoor could well have bowled himself out of political favour in this latest game. It's not quite cricket and not quite the way Congress plays its politics either.

with Bhavna Vij-Aurora

Kochi Cooling

The Tharoor-Modi clash may force the IPL to come clean on the convoluted ownership of its star-fronted teams

By Sharda Ugra

There is a great rumbling happening in the very heart of the cricket's El Dorado. The earth is not moving at all in the high offices of the "world's hottest sports league". Lalit Modi's worker ants are already making panic phone calls to prospective employers to tie up deals should cricket's Disneyland be torn down, and its colourful cast exiled into

the wilderness. Utter rubbish. Modi and his team are "not losing sleep. We're focused on the final weekend."

Modi vs Tharoor makes Kurosawa's *Rashomon* look an animation movie full of cuddlies. The Tharoor camp—and its Kochi franchise extension—has opened new lines of attack, including accusations of \$50 million in bribes and reported leaning on friends who can lean on the Enforcement Directorate to investigate the offshore arms of IPL's